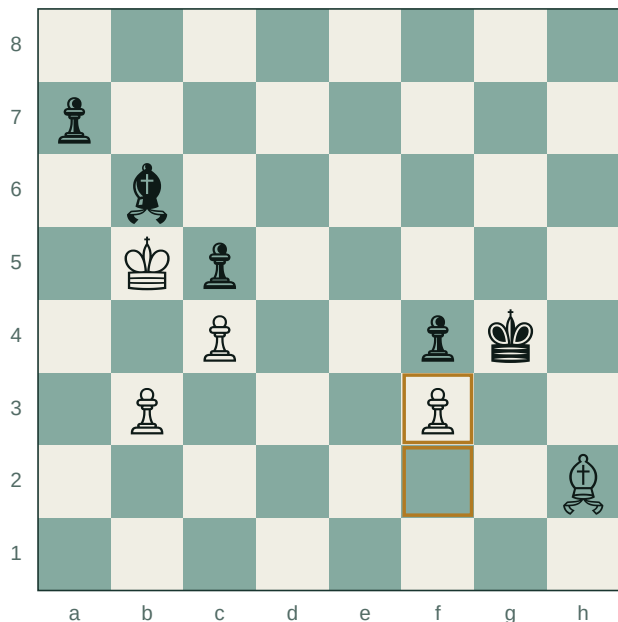


Bishop-ending decisions: Black, move 37

Bishop-ending decisions

Black to move



Previous move: 37.f3+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

37...Kxf3 38. b4 cxb4

37...Kxf3 The king captures the pawn on f3. Recorded reply: **38.b4**.

38...cxb4 The pawn captures the pawn on b4.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 6 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Same-colored and opposite-colored bishop endings have different tendencies, but neither label replaces calculation of the actual pawn races.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A bishop ending depends on diagonal access, pawn color, king activity, and promotion squares. Tactics can arise when a bishop must perform two defensive jobs.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the bishop's line to each target and identify pawns that can break its coverage or force it to move.

The defending king is on b5. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h2. Check for tactical protection.